

SETTING THE AGENDA
PM Modi addresses the nation from Red Fort on Independence Day, Aug. 15

PTI

MISSION PURGE

In a multi-pronged offensive, the Union government tightens laws and enforcement in its campaign against 'illegal' immigrants

- PM Modi announces high-powered 'demography mission' to target 'infiltration', says it is a demographic threat
- Four colonial-era immigration laws merged into the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025; Bureau of Immigration gets unprecedented powers
- MHA directs states/UTs to set up holding centres/ detention camps for suspected illegal foreigners pending removal
- Upgrades Assam's Foreigners Tribunals to first-class judicial magistrate status, empowers them to issue arrest warrants
- Big shift from slow, formal deportations to large-scale 'push-backs'; detainees moved to outposts and pushed across no man's land at the Bangladesh border
- BJP-ruled states like Rajasthan, Haryana, Delhi and Maharashtra start rounding up Bengali-speaking Muslims and deporting them as 'illegal Bangladeshis'. Many later prove to be Indian citizens from West Bengal
- Pushes a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls (Bihar first; to extend to poll-bound states) to verify electors and weed out suspected non-citizens

ship is being redrawn through voter suppression disguised as reform. "By sharpening the demographic debate," says Jairam Ramesh, Congress general secretary in-charge communications, "the Modi government is clearly positioning itself with an eye on the upcoming assembly elections in Bihar, Assam and West Bengal. It is, unmistakably, an electoral strategy aimed at the eastern states."

The Opposition's charge draws strength from precedent. After the Pahalgam terror attack in April this year, several BJP-ruled states rounded up Bengali-speaking Muslims, many of them Indian citizens, and branded them 'illegal Bangladeshis'. In West Bengal, the episode left a deep scar, prompting chief minister Mamata Banerjee to accuse the BJP of conflating Bengali identity with Bangladeshi nationality, weaponising language itself. "The courts have repeatedly exposed the BJP's misplaced claims," says Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP Sushmita Dev. "Several Bengali-speaking Muslims, pushed into Bangladesh forcibly or harassed in BJP-ruled states, were later found to be Indian citizens. The real reason is clear to everyone...documents and divisive politics cannot substitute for fairness and constitutional due process."

A New Demographic Reorder

For the moment, the demography mission exists more as an idea than an institution, without a structure, budget or timeline. Yet PM Modi and his colleagues are amping up the rhetoric and linking the mission to the anxieties of border states around immigration. On a three-day swing-by through Mizoram, Manipur, Assam, West Bengal and Bihar in September, the PM tailored his message to local grievances, from invoking cross-border in-